band at a dharmashala across the street playing nostalgic Bollywood golden oldies from my youth.

The Realm of the Chandelas

The origins of the Chandela Dynasty (831–1308 CE) remain obscure. Some historians have noted their early tribal associations, their worship of a tribal deity, Maniya Devi, and 'connections with the tribal Gonds and Bhars, [including] family ties with the Gonds'.[12] If the Chandelas had the subaltern social lineage this suggests, it likely made them insecure in their claims of royal entitlements, which may be why they tried so hard to invent a 'more respectable' Kshatriya genealogy. In due course, they were able to morph their identity into Rajputs of the lunar line, i.e, *Chandravanshi*s, through myth-making. One of their founding myths, recorded on an inscription, traces their descent and name to sage Chandratreya, son of the Vedic sage Atri, who was born from a one-night stand between—you guessed it—a Brahmin's ravishing daughter, Hemavati, and the moon god!

Until the early seventh century, the region had been part of the Gupta Empire (319–605 CE). New styles of temple art, architecture, engineering, governance, as well as religious and secular culture patronized by the Guptas entered the region, which the Chandelas later inherited.[13] After the Guptas, the control of the region passed to Harsha of Kannauj (ruled 606–47 CE), then to the Gurjara-Pratiharas. Early Chandela chiefs, based in Khajuraho, were mere vassals of the Gurjara-Pratiharas until their seventh in line, Yashovarman, broke free in the mid-tenth century and declared a sovereign state. To commemorate his victory, he stole a prized statue of Vaikunth-Vishnu from a Gurjara-Pratihara temple and installed it in a grand new temple he built at Khajuraho. The Chandela realm, Jejakabhukti, now extended 700 km from Varanasi to Vidisha, and was bounded by four rivers: Yamuna, Narmada, Chambal and Tons.

Yashovarman is said to have inaugurated a 'golden age' that lasted about a hundred years, with relative peace and prosperity, stable administration and where sculptural art, architecture, literature, theatre, dance and music flourished, all actively patronized by him and many successors. Of the twenty-odd Chandela rulers, none were women.